

Serologic Testing for Acquired Immunodeficiency Syndrome (AIDS)

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Tracking Information

Publication Number

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Manual Section Number

190.9

Manual Section Title

Serologic Testing for Acquired Immunodeficiency Syndrome (AIDS)

Version Number

1

Effective Date of this Version

08/12/1987

Description Information

Benefit Category

Diagnostic Laboratory Tests

Please Note: This may not be an exhaustive list of all applicable Medicare benefit categories for this item or service.

Item/Service Description

Serologic testing is employed to detect antibodies to the AIDS virus, which is currently identified by the term "human immunodeficiency virus (HIV)." The virus originally was named "human T-cell lymphotropic virus, type III (HTLV-III), a term that remains in common usage.

Antibodies may be detected by a variety of immunoassay techniques, the most common being an enzyme linked immunosorbent assay (ELISA). When an assay is reactive on initial testing, it should be repeated on the same specimen. A more specific test, (Western blot, immunofluorescent assay) is usually performed following repeatedly reactive ELISA results.

Indications and Limitations of Coverage

These tests may be covered when performed to help determine a diagnosis for symptomatic patients. They are not covered when furnished as part of a screening program for

asymptomatic persons.

NOTE: Two enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay (ELISA) tests that were conducted on the same specimen must both be positive before Medicare will cover the Western blot test.

Transmittal Information

Transmittal Number

33

Revision History

07/1987 - Provided coverage when needed to help determine a diagnosis for symptomatic patients and coverage when furnished as part of a screening program for asymptomatic people. Effective date 08/12/1987. (TN 17)

Additional Information

Other Versions

Title	Version	Effective Between	
Serologic Testing for Acquired Immunodeficiency Syndrome (AIDS)	1	08/12/1987 - N/A	You are here